

track info

tracks 25-27

Lee Hodgson explores the style of a very accomplished country great.

25. Introduction

26. Full track

27. Backing track

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rating info

beginner easy moderate hard



rating: moderate to hard

Executing the phrases cleanly and soulfully will require control, particularly in terms of fingering. Tone is an issue too – and remember: no plectrums please boys and girls!

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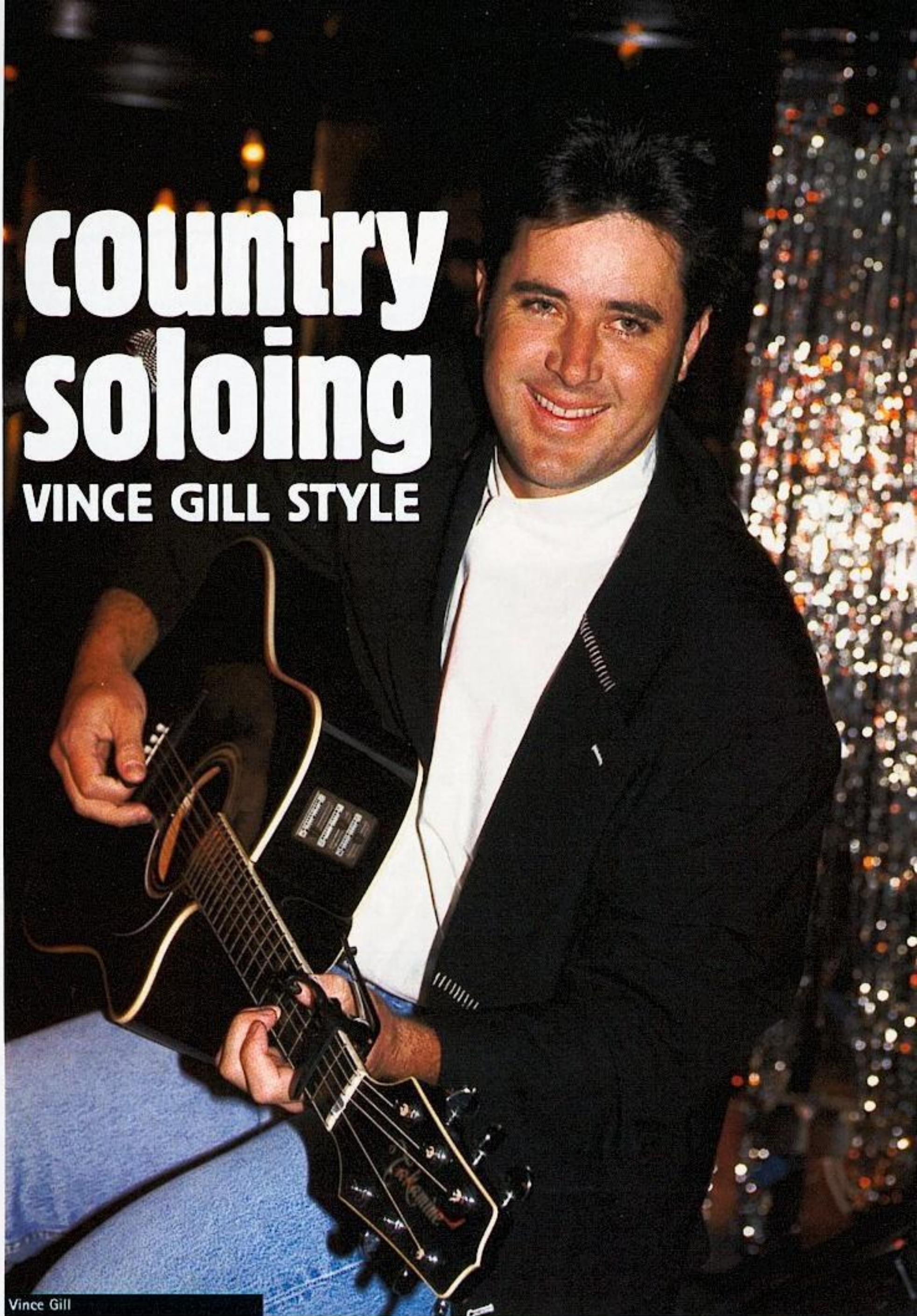
meet your gt tutor: lee hodgson

Lee Hodgson has been the country-rock specialist at London's prestigious Guitar Institute since 1989. He teaches other styles, too, having over 20 years of professional playing experience including gigging, touring and recording (Lee currently plays MIDI guitar and sings lead vocals with Memphis Roots). Lee also has an occasional column in our sister magazine, *Guitarist*. Lee endorses Fret-King guitars, Picato Strings and PM Tubes.



country soloing

VINCE GILL STYLE



Vince Gill

Find out why Vince Gill has connections with some of the biggest names in guitar, including Mark Knopfler and David Gilmour...

Let's get a bit of trivia out of the way first: apart from both Vince Gill and David Gilmour being extremely tasteful players, they have also been honoured by having a signature set of pick-ups made commercially available (by EMG). And what Vince said to Mark Knopfler, would you believe, was a polite "thanks, but no thanks" when Mark offered him a job in Dire Straits. That decision was given so that Vince could concentrate on his blossoming career – and indeed he has become one of country music's

most highly respected singer-songwriters (Garth Brooks once said about his own vocal abilities, "Hey, I'm no Vince Gill..."). Vince is a multi-talented musician who plays a mean fiddle and pedal-steel guitar too, although it's his guitar playing which is his main strength. Okay, let's take a look at the solo on offer this month, which is presented over last month's chord progression.

performance notes

The way I hear it, Vince's Gill's picking occasionally shows tendencies towards the twang

of James Burton and also sounds rather like Albert Lee at times too (Vince and Albert toured together a while back). But as regards the soulful soloing on ballads such as the piece on offer here, I'm certain Vince has been influenced by the sweet, vaguely jazzy touches of West Coast fusion pioneer Larry Carlton. Whatever, I'd recommend dialling in a warm, almost breaking-up sort of tone and, as I have done on the **gtCD**, use flesh-only plucking to maximise the dynamics and keep it all sweet sounding.

Bar 1 is a typical major pentatonic scale lick of the kind Vince uses quite often. Notice how it blends seamlessly into the almost jazzy minor lick in bar 2 – try thinking in phrases, or pairs of licks at least, in order to sound cohesive.

Bar 3 begins in a similar fashion to the first lick but played down an octave – it's nice when familiar moves are heard a few times within an individual solo. The interest comes when you vary the idea or feature some kind of permutation (simply modifying the melody to suit a fresh chord is often all that's required). Coming out of bar 3 into bar 4 is a phrase very much in the style of Larry Carlton, especially when you consider the nature of the accompaniment. Observe how, at the end of bar 4, the lick anticipates the return to the tonic chord, D.

At this point I'd like to offer a brief theory lesson concerning the chord progression heard in bars 6 and 7 as it touches upon an important compositional tool. The most common and successful way to approach a chord is via its dominant (or V) chord. In fact, almost any chord can be targeted this way, not just the tonic. So, let's consider the sub-dominant chord in the key of D, which is G. You could approach that via D7 – which would introduce a non-diatonic sound (D7 is not in the key of D major). To elaborate, if you have a dominant chord that's used to go to somewhere other than the tonic chord, then it's functioning as what's known as a 'secondary dominant'. Okay, but why don't we approach the D7 from its own V chord (which would be A)? The trouble is, though, A dominant 7 would sound jarring in the context of the section, yet Am(7) sounds just right. So, by realising that, reaching a dominant 7 chord from its own V chord (minor) is a crafty way of reaching a major chord a fourth above the dominant 7 chord. And what's actually heard in bar 6 is Am7 to C/D – which is a **chord synonym**

sound advice

lee's gtCD gear

I selected the bridge-and-middle pick-up position on my Fret-King Corona guitar (11-58 Picato strings) via a RipCord into the 'hi' input of a Cornford Harlequin which was set as follows:

Vol	Bass	Treb	Master
6.8	6.2	6.9	6.9

The combo was miked with a Shure SM58. At mixdown reverb was added courtesy of a Yamaha Rev 500 ('Big Church') and a bit of in-tempo delay was added using a Lexicon MPX1.

of D11, in itself a fancier version of D7. Whatever you call it, that resolves up a fourth to G – well actually it's Gmajor9, no third, in the guise of its equivalent (D/G). The point of this analysis is to consider the nature of such fairly sophisticated chord progressions and objectively mould guitar lines over them to suit; there should be at least some thought involved although it's a fairly straightforward sequence to feel your way through by ear. To recap briefly, what is heard here is effectively a 'major ii-V' (in G, despite the song being in D overall). Accordingly, realise that ii-Vs are heard in many styles of music, not only jazz!

Bars 6 and 7, as just discussed, could therefore tolerate a fairly fusion-esque approach (it's still reminiscent of Larry Carlton at this point isn't it?). And so it goes for the next few bars as well... Work on getting the phrases to sound convincing – try to sound sophisticated!

Here's just a bit more theory: the D/E in bar 11 could have been simply an Em7 – which would have been the logical choice given that the next chord is Asus4 (the dominant of D) – recognise what I've just described as a ii-V? Anyway, what's good about substituting Em7 with D/E – which could also be seen as E11 – is that it rather obviously features the D note, which is the key note or tonic. This effectively means that simply playing 'in key', as it were, sounds particularly good – boldly playing 'in D' over the D/E and subsequent Asus4 chords sounds right. That's a descending D major scale then that I used to close the solo (I wasn't thinking A Mixolydian, by the way).

I hope you enjoy learning this solo and appreciate the challenge of trying to execute it convincingly. Of course, you may also wish to keep playing over the **gtCD** backing track to experiment with some ideas of your own. **gt**

jargon buster



chord synonyms

Chord synonyms are simply chords by another name. For example, A11 = G/A; Am7 = C/A; F#m7#5 = D Add9/F#.



REMEMBER terms and signs are fully explained on page 94

gt info

further listening

Vince Gill, apart from being a session singer/guitarist with many of the country greats, has recorded several highly recommended albums under his own name, all of which feature fantastic guitar playing. Check out all of the following (on MCA): *I Still Believe In You*; *Pocket Full of Gold*; *When Love Finds You*; *High Lonesome Sound*; *The Key*; *Let's Make Sure We Kiss Goodbye*.

country soloing vince gill style

Ballad ♩ = 68

mf

gliss

gliss slight vib

gliss

gliss

faint gliss

3

warm clean tone S H S BD LB S H PO S S CO

GT TAB

9 11 10 12 10 9 (9) (10) 9 7 6 7 6 7 9 9 (9)

1 Dsus2 Bm7



country soloing vince gill style



country soloing vince gill style... continued

3 **Cmaj13** **A11**

mp H H *pf* PB LD (7)(8) 7 H+ PO S BU *mf* RPB LD (CO) PO CO S

gliss

5 7 5 7 (7) 8 5-10(12) (12) (12)-10 8 12-10 8 9-11 10

5 **D** **Am7** **C/D**

slight vib (CO) CO BU LD PO BU (CO)

(10) (11) 8 9(11) 9 7 7 (7) 10 10 (10) 8 7 10(12) 8-10

7 9 11

7 **D/G** **Gm7**

Nat harms Let ring S Nh *mp*

12 7 12 7 10 8 6 10 6 12 (12) 5 5 2 3

gliss vib Nat harms

7 (3) (7) 10 8 6 10 6 12 (12) 5 5 2 3

9 **F#m7#5(Dadd9)** **Bm7,11**

fp H PO H PO CO S *mf* S S PO

vib gliss gliss gliss

5 0 2 (2) 0 4 3 5 3 7 (7) 7 5 7 5 3 5 4 4

11 **D/E** **Asus4** (to verse in D)

mp S BU *mf* (LD) S *mp* S S

gliss dolce vib gliss gliss gliss

(4) 4 7 (7) 9 (11) (11) (11) 8 9 (9) 7 6 7 9 7 (7)